

WILD & CO VOYAGES · ECUADOR · 0°45′S 90°19′W

The Galápagos Islands, *Read in Order of Age*

A field guide to Galápagos cruises, land journeys and wildlife, island by island

PREPARED FOR

Jane Traveler

TRAVELER FOLIO · JW-F-0001

COVER · SEA LION, SANTA FE · PHOTO PIKAIA LODGE GALÁPAGOS

A LETTER BEFORE YOU GO

Dear Jane,

I first came here in 1991, and I still remember the feeling: I was Darwin. A small airport, a handful of boats in the whole archipelago, no guide at my elbow, and almost no one else going. You stepped off the panga and the islands simply carried on, sea lions asleep on the landing, boobies nesting on the path, a hawk close enough to touch, none of them the least bit bothered by us.

I've kept going back ever since, and the reason hasn't changed. The animals still don't care that we're there. The rock is still being made in the west and worn down in the east, so every island is a different chapter. And every time I go, I see something I walked straight past the time before. It's the one place I know where you come home more curious than when you left.

Today far more people come, so how you go matters. Small ships, the right season, and a naturalist who has been doing this for decades. That's what this guide is for. Start with the rock, read the islands oldest to youngest, and the wildlife makes sense.

This guide is page one of your Folio. Mark it up. Circle what makes you grin. Cross out what doesn't. When we talk, I'll already know which kind of traveler you are.

J. Wild CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER · FIRST LANDED 1991

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

	1991, when I first came	Today
VISITORS	Fewer than 50,000 a year (early 1990s)	About 330,000 a year (2023)
THE WAY IN	A small airport and a handful of boats	Daily flights, busy harbour towns and a long list of licensed ships
THE ANIMALS	Unafraid	Still unafraid. That's the miracle.

How to read the marks in this guide

Every place, ship and lodge carries one stamp from the Ledger. It tells you exactly how well we know it. Nothing gets a stamp it hasn't earned.

I KNOW A PLACE *I slept here*	James has stayed there himself.	I'VE WALKED IT *vetted on foot*	Inspected in person, every path and room.
I KEEP GOING BACK *founder favourite*	The places James returns to on his own time.	I KNOW THE HOST *the house patches you in*	A personal introduction comes with the booking.
I KNOW WHO KNOWS *partner vetted*	Vetted through a partner we trust, like Royal Galapagos.	I'LL KNOW SOON *well worth the visit*	On James's list. Recommended, honestly marked.

IN THIS GUIDE

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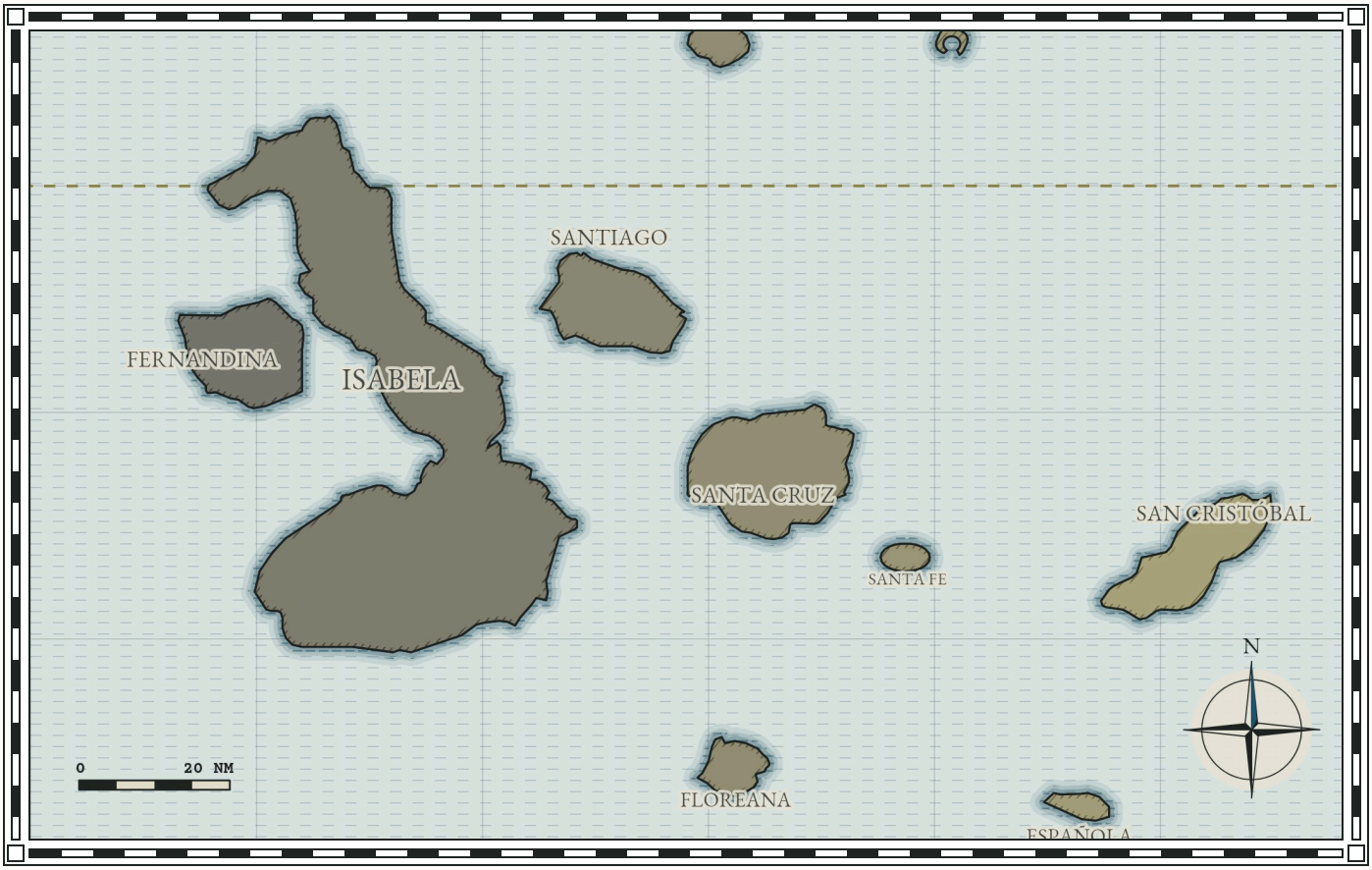
Read it in order, like the islands. Or start with the page that made you pick it up.

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"The islands are born in the west and carried east.
Read them in that order, and everything makes sense."

J. Wild

A conveyor belt you can stand on



◀ YOUNGER · WEST · well under a million years

OLDER · EAST · roughly 3-4 million years ▶



The oldest residents keep the slowest schedule. Take the hint.

Photo: Pikaia Lodge

Wildlife without fear

Animals here evolved without hunters on land, and they still behave like it. You'll step around sea lions, not stalk them.

Geology you can read

Old islands in the east are worn and green; young ones in the west are black lava and still active. Sail one to the other and you watch the place being made.

A park that says no

The National Park sets every landing and time. Fewer people at each site, a naturalist with every group, and rules that keep it this way.

LINGER LONGER *"Give the islands enough days to tell the story in order. Five days is a trailer." — J. W.*

Never trust a brochure with no weather in it

	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
Season	warm	warm	warm	warm	warm	garúa	garúa	garúa	garúa	garúa	garúa	warm
Sea (approx.)	24–26°	24–26°	24–26°	24–26°	24–26°	19–22°	19–22°	19–22°	19–22°	19–22°	19–22°	24–26°
Albatross, Española	·	·	·	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●
Best for	snorkel	snorkel	snorkel	snorkel	snorkel	wildlife	wildlife	wildlife	wildlife	wildlife	wildlife	snorkel

DECEMBER – MAY

The warm season

Warmer water, calmer seas, green highlands and short showers. The snorkeler's choice.

JUNE – NOVEMBER

The garúa season

The Humboldt Current brings cool water, misty mornings and the richest marine life. Rougher crossings, livelier wildlife.



Blue-footed boobies: the dance is real, and it is not for you

Photo: Pikaia Lodge

> *There's no bad month. There's only the month that suits you. Tell me whether you'd rather be warm or wowed, and I'll tell you when to go.*
> *– J. Wild*

Wildlife timing is approximate and varies by year; your naturalist confirms on the day.



A pile of marine iguanas. The collective noun is a mess. Accurate.

Who the Galápagos is for, and who it isn't

The short answer: almost anyone curious, and nobody in a hurry. Here's how I'd match you, by the kind of traveler you are. My notes are in the margin, as always.

BEST FOR
Curious people who like animals more than shopping

IDEAL LENGTH
8 to 15 days; 5 is a trailer

BEST TIME
Any month. Dec–May warm and calm, Jun–Nov cooler and wilder

HOW
Small ship, land lodge, or both

MADE FOR YOU IF YOU'RE…

First-timers
Come for the tortoises, leave rewriting your bucket list.
OUR PICK · THE CONTRAST · 9 DAYS, LAND THEN SEA

Families, kids about 8 and up
The only classroom where the homework naps on your towel.
OUR PICK · PIKAIA BY LAND, OR TAKE THE WHOLE YACHT

Couples & honeymooners
Romantic, though the blue-footed boobies will out-dance you.
OUR PICK · SEA STAR BALCONY SUITE, CRUISE A

Snorkelers & divers
Penguins on the equator. You'll stop trying to explain it.
OUR PICK · CRUISE C · THE YOUNG WEST

Photographers
For once the problem is the animals are too close.
OUR PICK · ESPAÑOLA & GENOVESA

Three generations
Grandparents on the sundeck, kids in the water, everyone at dinner.
OUR PICK · CHARTER THE WHOLE YACHT

Solo travelers
Sixteen guests. You'll leave with fifteen friends.
OUR PICK · SEA STAR · ASK ABOUT SINGLE RATES

THINK TWICE IF YOU'RE…

Bad sailors
The Pacific doesn't read itineraries.
OUR PICK · SLEEP ASHORE AT PIKAIA; DAY BOATS ONLY

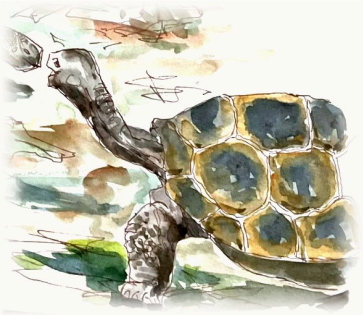
Night owls
Lights out around nine. The stars are the after-party.
OUR PICK · ADD TWO NIGHTS IN QUITO

Beach loungers
The beaches are perfect, and already taken by sea lions.
OUR PICK · PAIR IT WITH ONE OF OUR BEACH STAYS

Anyone in a hurry
Five days is a trailer. You came for the film.
OUR PICK · STRETCH TO THE FULL CIRCLE

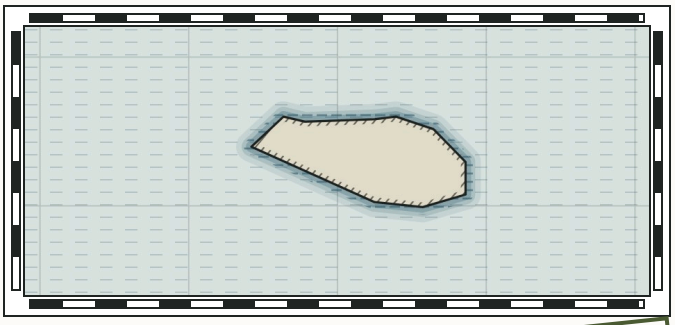
Limited mobility
Wet landings, lava underfoot, pangas that bob.
OUR PICK · PIKAIA AND THE GENTLER SITES; TELL US AND WE'LL PLAN AROUND IT

Minimum ages and landing rules vary by ship [confirm per program]. If you're not sure where you fit, that's what the call is for.



Never in a hurry. Take the hint.

Six islands worth the crossing



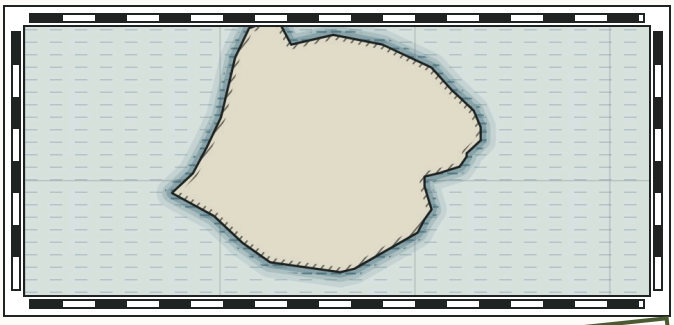
Española

The elder

I'VE WALKED IT

Waved albatross (about Apr–Dec), the Suárez blowhole, sea lions on Gardner Bay.

Dry & wet landings · Cruise A



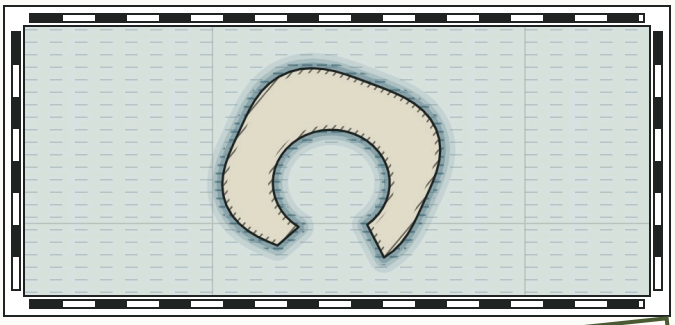
Floreana

Pirates and post

I'VE WALKED IT

Flamingos at Cormorant Point, snorkelling Devil's Crown, the Post Office Bay barrel.

Wet landings · Cruise A



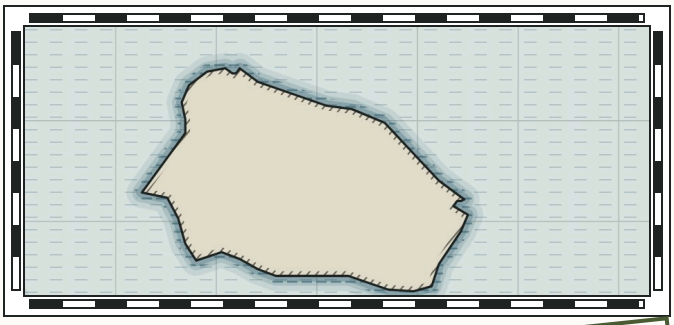
Genovesa

The bird island

I'VE WALKED IT

Red-footed boobies, frigatebirds, storm petrels and, with luck, short-eared owls.

Dry & wet landings · Cruise B



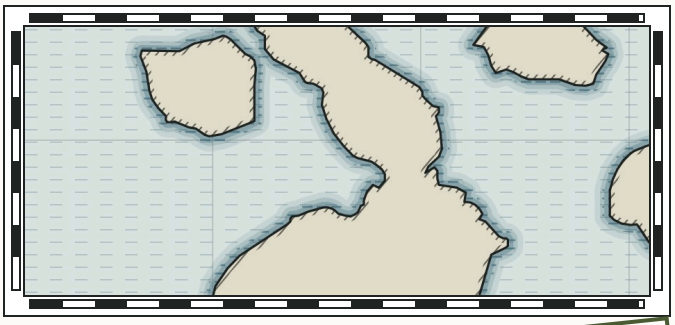
Santiago & Bartolomé

The lava fields

I'VE WALKED IT

Pinnacle Rock from the summit, fresh pāhoehoe at Sullivan Bay, fur seals at Egas Port.

Dry & wet landings · Cruises B & C



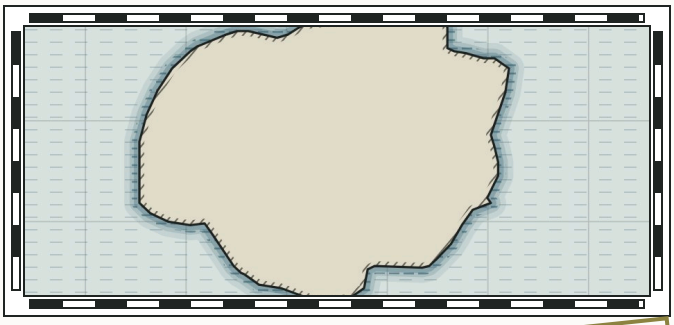
Isabela & Fernandina

The young west

I'VE WALKED IT

Marine iguanas by the hundred, flightless cormorants, penguins on the equator.

Dry & wet landings · Cruise C



Santa Cruz

The highlands

I'LL KNOW SOON

Wild tortoises in the cloud forest, the breeding center, and Pikaia Lodge on the volcano.

Road & day boat · All journeys

Sample stamps for layout. James confirms each island's mark before release.

IV · TWO WAYS TO SEE IT

By sea, by land, or both

	BY SEA · SEA STAR	BY LAND · PIKAIA LODGE	BOTH · THE CONTRAST
Where you sleep	One suite that moves with you	One room on the Santa Cruz highlands, about 1,500 ft up	Three nights ashore, then the ship
Reach	The whole archipelago, incl. Genovesa & Fernandina	Islands near Santa Cruz by day yacht; no overnights at sea	Central islands, then the far west
Pace	Two landings a day	Day trips, then home to the lodge	Slow, then deep
Sea legs	Night crossings	Sleep on land every night	Land first, sea once you're ready
Suits	Wildlife purists, solo travelers, charters	Families, poor sleepers at sea, hikers	First-timers with time
Nights	4–14	3 or more	3 + 5
From	$[____] pp	$[____] pp	$[____] pp



Your own deck for the passing islands Photo: Royal Galapagos



A balcony king room: the bed that doesn't move Photo: Pikaia Lodge

The linger-o-meter

The same archipelago at three speeds. What each adds, and what you miss without it.

5

DAYS · CRUISE B

Genovesa's birds, Bartolomé's view, the highlands.

You miss: the old south, the young west.

9

DAYS · THE CONTRAST

Highlands and tortoises, then Isabela and Fernandina.

You miss: Española's albatross.

15

DAYS · THE FULL CIRCLE

Oldest to youngest, all three routes, one suite.

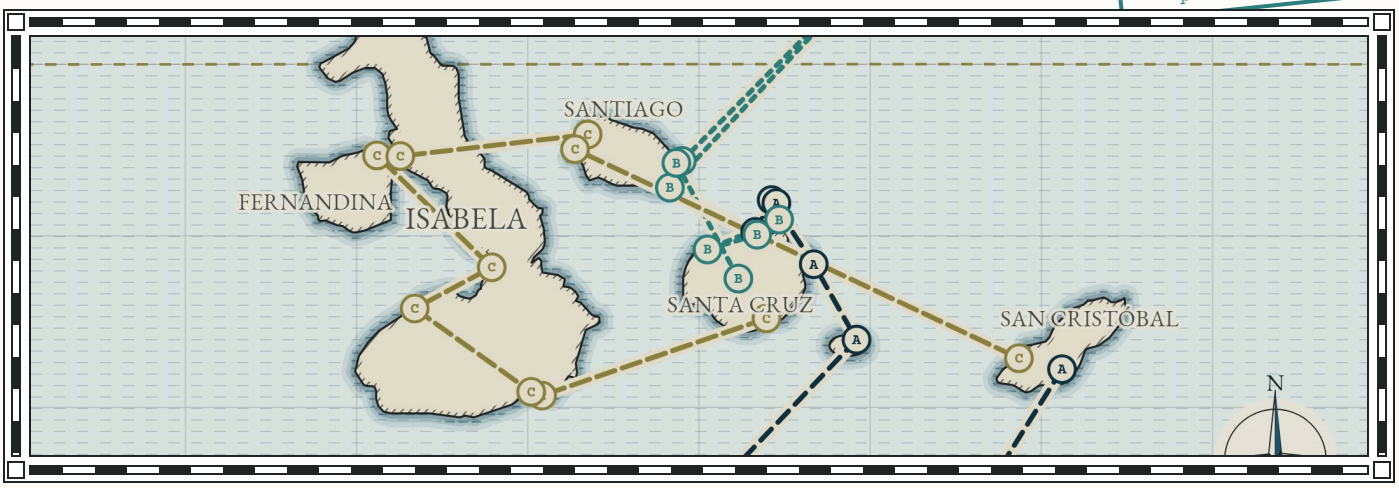
You miss: nothing but the office.

LINGER LONGER *"The third day is when the animals stop being a surprise and start being neighbours." — J. W.*

Oldest to Youngest

JW-VYG-004 · GALÁPAGOS SEA STAR · 16 GUESTS · 8 SUITES · WITH ROYAL GALAPAGOS

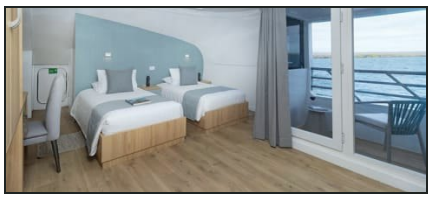
I KNOW WHO KNOWS
partner vetted



Cruise A — — the old south · Cruise B · · · the north · Cruise C — — the young west



The Galapagos Sea Star, our Oldest to Youngest voyage yacht Photo: Royal Galapagos



Balcony suite: worth it for the 6 a.m. light alone Photo: Royal Galapagos



Fire & Frigatebirds: the courtship display that names a voyage Photo: Pikaia Lodge

A	**Tue–Sun · The Old South.** San Cristóbal, Española, Floreana, Santa Fe, South Plaza, North Seymour.
B	**Sun–Thu · Fire & Frigatebirds.** Dragon Hill, Black Turtle Cove, Genovesa, Bartolomé, the highlands.
C	**Thu–Tue · The Young West.** Isabela, Sierra Negra, Elizabeth Bay, Fernandina, Santiago, Lobos.
A+B+C	**15 days · The Full Circle.** All three, back to back, one suite. Guests change at Baltra; you stay aboard.

WHO IT SUITS

Wildlife purists, solo travelers, families, and groups who take the whole yacht (8 suites, 16 guests).

FROM

$[_____] pp · 4 nights

TIME REWARDED

Sail the Full Circle: [__]% off the third leg.

TR-GAL-JW-F-0001

QR

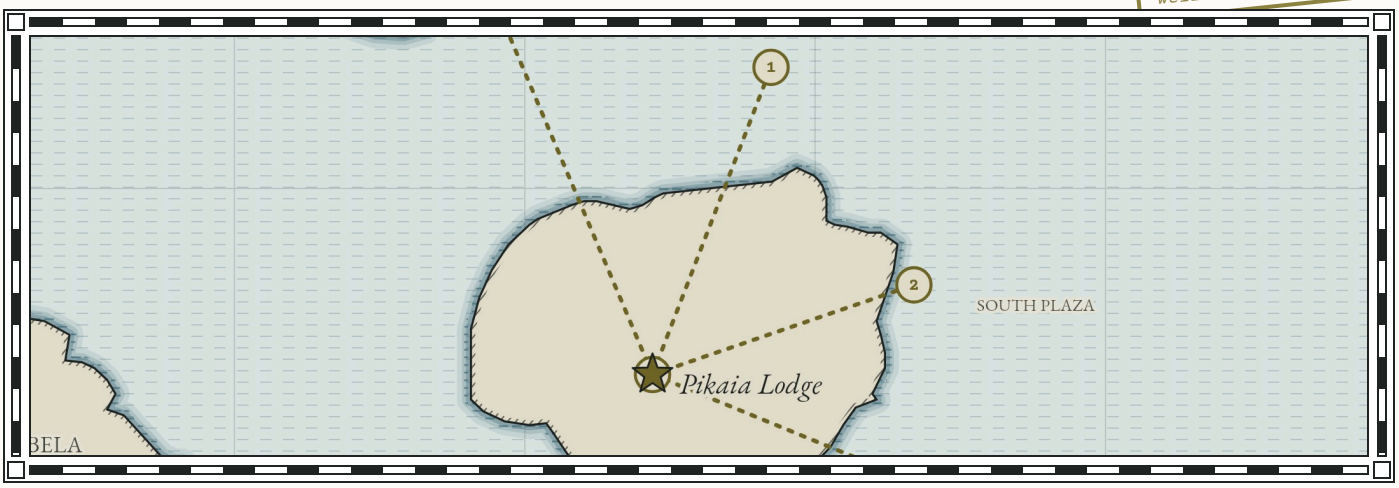
Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"If you can only do one, do the one with Fernandina in it." — J. W.*

Highlands & Day Boats

SAMPLE LAND JOURNEY · PIKAIA LODGE, SANTA CRUZ · 14 ROOMS · ABOUT 1,500 FT UP

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit



Day trips by the lodge's own yacht · sample sites, set by the lodge and the Park



Highlands & Day Boats: the lodge sits on the rim of two extinct craters Photo: Pikaia Lodge



Sleep in one bed, see the islands by day boat Photo: Pikaia Lodge



The sea lion will find you. Let it. Photo: Pikaia Lodge

Day 1	**Up the volcano.** Land at Baltra, drive to the highlands. Tortoises on the lodge trails by evening.
Day 2	**North Seymour by yacht.** Frigatebirds and blue-footed boobies at nesting distance; back for dinner.
Day 3	**South Plaza & Santa Fe.** Land iguanas and a snorkel stop.
Day 4	**Bartolomé.** The summit view over Pinnacle Rock.
Day 5	**Garrapatero.** Bike to the beach, then fly home.

The lodge yacht runs day trips only, so it reaches the islands near Santa Cruz. For Genovesa or Fernandina, see the Contrast.

WHO IT SUITS

Families, travelers who sleep badly at sea, hikers, and anyone who wants one room for the whole stay.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 4 nights

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night at Pikaia: [offer to confirm].

WAN-GAL-JW-F-0001

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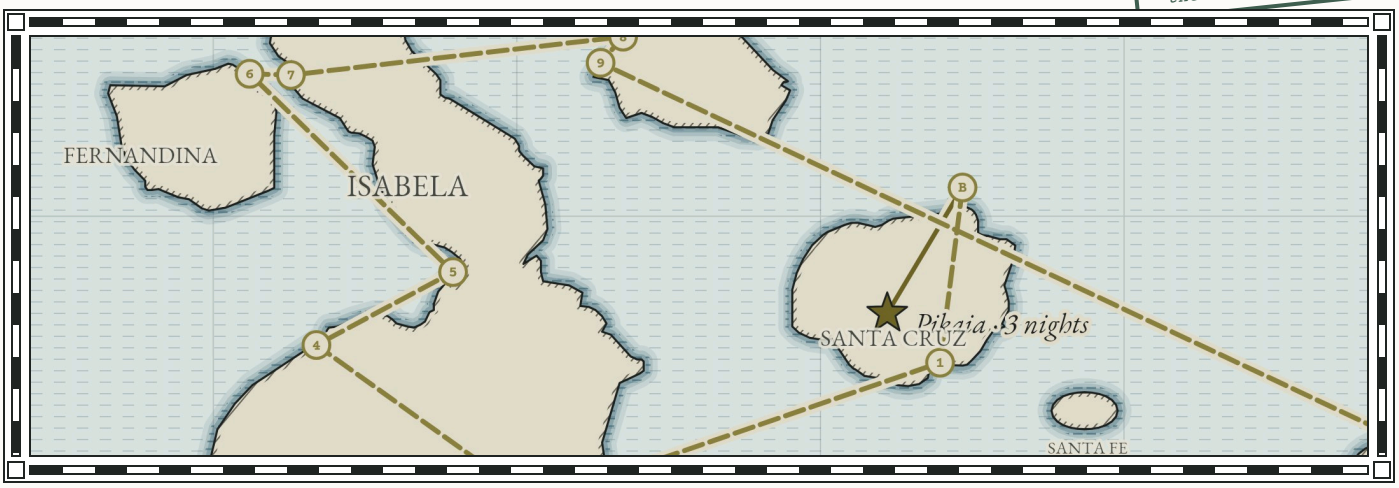
Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Wake up to tortoises, fall asleep without a single wave. Some people call that cheating. I call it smart." — J. W.*

The Contrast

JW-CON-G01 · 3 NIGHTS AT PIKAIA, THEN CRUISE C ABOARD THE SEA STAR · 9 DAYS

HOUSE FAVOURITE
the James Wild way



Pikaia Lodge, three nights · then Cruise C west to Isabela and Fernandina



Worth Another Night, earned at the pool Photo: Pikaia Lodge



The sundeck, best seat for frigatebirds riding the mast Photo: Royal Galapagos



The only lizard on earth that swims for its supper Photo: Pikaia Lodge

Mon	**Arrive Baltra.** Up to Pikaia; tortoises before dinner.
Tue–Wed	**Day boats from the highlands.** North Seymour, then Bartolomé or the Plazas.
Thu	**Board the Sea Star.** Cruise C begins at Baltra; the breeding center that afternoon.
Fri–Mon	**The young west.** Isabela, Fernandina, Santiago.
Tue	**Lobos Island, fly home.** From San Cristóbal.

WHO IT SUITS

First-timers with nine days, couples, and anyone nervous about a first night at sea.

FROM

$[____] pp · 8 nights

THE CONTRAST RATE

Land plus sea, priced together: [__].

CON-GAL-JW-F-0001

QR

Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Good journeys have seams. Land, then sea. You should feel the change." — J. W.*

Every boat we'd put you on

Each can be chartered whole, 4 to 15 days, with naturalists, crew and every meal. Sixteen to twenty guests means every one of you is on the first panga.



Galapagos Sea Star

I KNOW WHO KNOWS

YACHT · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Our Oldest to Youngest yacht. Two jacuzzis, triple and connecting cabins.



Galapagos Horizon

I'LL KNOW SOON

TRIMARAN · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

A balcony in every cabin. Three hulls for the channel crossings.



Infinity

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · LUXURY · 20 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Two bilingual naturalists and balconies throughout. Good for big families.



Natural Paradise

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Upper-deck balcony suites plus a main-deck suite.



Grand Majestic

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · LUXURY · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

A true master suite. The one for an anniversary charter.



Galapagos Angel

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · FIRST CLASS · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Two upper-deck suites and a friendlier price.



Calipso

I'LL KNOW SOON

YACHT · FIRST CLASS · 16 GUESTS · ROYAL GALAPAGOS

Cabins across three decks. Solid, unfussy, well run.



Origin · Theory · Evolve

I'LL KNOW SOON

EXPEDITION YACHTS · 20 GUESTS · 10 STATEROOMS · ECOVENTURA

Three sister yachts. Pick by itinerary, not by name.



Hermes

I'LL KNOW SOON

MEGA CATAMARAN · 2025 · 20 GUESTS · 12 SUITES · VIANATURA

164 feet, 20 crew, two butlers. The new benchmark for a whole-ship charter.

CHARTER THE WHOLE SHIP *"Take the whole boat and the itinerary becomes a conversation, not a brochure."*

— J. W. Charter rates from $[____]

Photos: Royal Galapagos, Ecoventura, Vianatura. Marks are samples until confirmed.

VI · LINGER

Slower is the whole point



Worth Another Night, earned at the pool Photo: Pikaia Lodge

Most Galápagos regrets are about time, not money. People fly a long way, see one route, and spend the flight home wondering about the other islands. We'd rather you stayed.

That's why the house sets a three-night minimum on land, and why our offers reward staying longer rather than booking sooner.

Three nights or don't bother. Night one you unpack. Night two you notice. Night three the place starts talking.
— J. Wild

TIME REWARDED

Sail the Full Circle

15 days, one suite, `[__]%` off the third leg.

`TR-GAL-JW-F-0001`

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night at Pikaia

`[offer to confirm with the lodge]`

`WAN-GAL-JW-F-0001`

ON THE HORIZON

Not this year? Next.

2028 departures with early-planner savings of `[__]`.

`OTH-GAL-JW-F-0001`

Codes are tied to your Folio ID so your advisor sees which offer you chose.



Green turtles swim right under you, mildly curious at most.

The Galápagos entries

ENTRY	PLACE	MARK	MARGIN NOTE
L-101	Galápagos Sea Star · Royal Galapagos	I KNOW WHO KNOWS	*Sixteen guests. The naturalist decides, and is usually right.*
L-102	Pikaia Lodge · Santa Cruz highlands	I'LL KNOW SOON	*On the list for my next run west.*
L-103	Española · Suárez Point	I'VE WALKED IT	*Albatross from April. Bring patience and a hat.*
L-104	Genovesa · El Barranco	I'VE WALKED IT	*The bird island. Long lens, short sleeves.*
L-105	Fernandina · Espinoza Point	I'VE WALKED IT	*Younger than some of your relatives.*

Sample entries for layout. Every stamp is confirmed by James before release.

Rules of the Road

01 **The smaller the boat, the bigger the sea.** First ashore, last back.

02 **Read a place in the order it was written.** Old islands first.

03 **Arrive the day before the day before.** Mainland flights run late; ships don't wait.

04 **Contrast beats coverage.** Land, then sea. You'll feel the change.

Words we've struck out

~~LUXURY CRUISE~~ — It's a yacht with sixteen guests and a naturalist who knows every sea lion by its scars.

~~HIDDEN GEM~~ — Nothing here is hidden. It's protected. Different thing.

~~ONCE IN A LIFETIME~~ — Most of our guests come back. I



Giant tortoises at feeding time. Slower than you think, and grumpier.

What to know, and what not to expect

Getting there

Fly to Guayaquil or Quito, then on to Baltra or San Cristóbal. Plan a night on the mainland first.

Fees at the door

Galápagos National Park entrance fee `[US$200 adult, confirm]` and Transit Control Card `[US$20, confirm]`.

Fitness

Wet landings from pangas, uneven lava, short hikes in the sun. Tell us about knees and backs; we'll match the route.

Pack

Reef-safe sunscreen, a brimmed hat with a strap, water shoes, a light layer for garúa mornings, a dry bag, and a long lens if you have one.

What not to expect

~~CASINO~~	The only gamble is whether the penguins show up.
~~FORMAL NIGHTS~~	Dress code: dry by dinner.
~~YOUR OWN LANDING TIMES~~	The Park sets the clock. Everyone keeps it.
~~HAND-FEEDING~~	Two metres from wildlife. The animals didn't get the memo.
~~STRONG WI-FI~~	Limited at sea `[confirm]`. Post the photos at home.

Straight answers

Sea or land first time? Sea reaches more; land sleeps better. The Contrast does both.

Solo? Welcome on both. Ask about the single supplement.

Children? Strong fit. Age guidance `[confirm per program]`.



Brown pelicans, the harbour's unpaid security.

Words you'll hear on board

Panga
The small inflatable boat that ferries you from ship to shore. Every landing starts with one.

Wet landing
You step off the panga into knee-deep water on a beach. Sandals, not socks.

Dry landing
You step from the panga onto rock or a jetty. Watch the swell, take the naturalist's hand.

Garúa
The cool, misty season (about June to November), when the Humboldt Current brings fog and rich seas.

Humboldt Current
Cold water flowing up from Antarctica. It feeds the penguins, fur seals and the best snorkelling.

Endemic
Found nowhere else on earth. In the Galápagos that covers most of the reptiles you will meet.

Hotspot
The plume of magma under the western islands that keeps building new land.

Pāhoehoe
Smooth, ropey lava, as on Santiago's Sullivan Bay. Beautiful, and hard on soft shoes.

Naturalist
Your Park-licensed guide. Every group ashore has one, by law.

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Your journey, in your hand

When I'd like to go

Who's coming

Sea, land or both ☐ Sea Star ☐ Pikaia ☐ The Contrast

The island I circled

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Til our next expedition,

James

JAMES PAPAGNO · CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER

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SOURCES Visitor figures: C. Hunt, "The Galápagos Islands," in Overtourism (early 1990s); Galápagos Insiders, citing official figures (2023). Fees, seasons and wildlife timing are guidance only; your naturalist and the Galápagos National Park have the final word.
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